

What else to watch: *A Star is Born* (1937) ■ *All About Eve* (1950, p.332) ■ *Some Like It Hot* (1959, pp.148–49) ■ *Whatever Happened to Baby Jane?* (1962)



silent era. Swanson herself had been a huge star of the silent screen, so in taking on the role of the deranged Miss Desmond, she creates a grotesque parody of her celebrity self.

The movie tells the story of Joe Gillis (William Holden), a down-on-his-luck screenwriter who falls in

Wilder's movie marked an extraordinary screen comeback for Gloria Swanson. She effectively retired from movies afterward.

with the reclusive Norma when she asks him to write her comeback movie. The aging diva is convinced that her millions of fans are waiting, “out there in the dark,” for her return to the silver screen.

Joe reluctantly moves into the star’s creepy mansion on Sunset Boulevard, and Norma falls in love with the young writer, who is drawn into her delusions. Joe eventually tries to escape Norma and salvage what little dignity he has left, but we know things end badly for him because his story is told in flashback; at the start of the movie he is a corpse floating in a swimming pool. “The poor dope. He always wanted a pool,” is Joe’s narration—a gallows-humor gag told from beyond the grave.

Silent tribute

Wilder’s movies are celebrated for their cynical dialogue and one-liners—“You’ll make a rope of words and strangle this business!” is one of Norma’s most memorable lines—but there is also a suggestion of melancholia in *Sunset Boulevard*. Beneath his cynicism, Wilder’s reverence for a vanished era is obvious. Ultimately, while there is a glittering monstrousness to the deluded Norma, she is also a tragic figure. Wilder suggests that she may have a point about the movies: that they lost some of their magic when their stars began to talk. ■



Billy Wilder
Director

“Nobody’s perfect” is the final line of Billy Wilder’s *Some Like It Hot*. All Wilder’s movies are based on this simple truth—with characters whose flaws are fascinating, from Fred MacMurray’s Walter Neff in *Double Indemnity* to Robert Stephens’s detective in *The Private Life of Sherlock Holmes* (1970). As a filmmaker, Wilder himself was as close to perfect as it’s possible to get.

Born in Austria in 1909, Samuel “Billy” Wilder fled the Nazis to make his directorial debut in Paris. In the 1930s he came to Hollywood, where he wrote movies with Charles Brackett. *Double Indemnity*, his collaboration with novelist Raymond Chandler, is often credited as the first film noir. His later movies were mostly comic, but retained the cynical bite—and eye for human weakness—of his earlier tragedies. He died in 2002.

Key movies

1944 *Double Indemnity*
1945 *The Lost Weekend*
1950 *Sunset Boulevard*
1955 *The Seven Year Itch*
1959 *Some Like It Hot*

